

Psalms 123

Unto Thee Lift I Up Mine Eyes

Unto thee lift I up mine eyes, O thou that dwellest in the heavens

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Unto thee lift I up mine eyes, O thou that dwellest in the heavens.*
- 2 *Behold, as the eyes of servants look unto the hand of their masters, and as the eyes of a maiden unto the hand of her mistress; so our eyes wait upon the LORD our God, until that he have mercy upon us.*
- 3 *Have mercy upon us, O LORD, have mercy upon us: for we are exceedingly filled with contempt.*
- 4 *Our soul is exceedingly filled with the scorning of those that are at ease, and with the contempt of the proud.*

2 • CONTEXT

One of the shortest Songs of Ascents, Psalm 123 captures a posture of dependent waiting under prolonged contempt, likening the worshiper's attentiveness to God to a servant's careful watch on a master's hand for the slightest signal. Its brevity intensifies its focus: nearly the entire psalm is occupied by waiting eyes and a single plea for mercy amid scorn. Henry treats the image of a servant's eyes fixed on a master's hand as a deliberate model of humble, attentive dependence rather than passive resignation.

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The psalm opens with eyes deliberately lifted toward the God who dwells in the heavens, then narrows that image sharply: as the eyes of servants look to the hand of their masters, and as a maiden's eyes look to her mistress's hand, so the psalmist's eyes wait upon the Lord, until he shows mercy—attentive, ready dependence rather than idle waiting.

Verse 3-4

The plea intensifies with repetition: have mercy, have mercy, because the psalmist is exceedingly filled with contempt. That contempt is specified as coming from those at ease and from the proud, scorn compounded by the fact that it comes from people who are comfortable and arrogant rather than themselves suffering.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Genuine dependence on God is pictured here not as passive resignation but as the alert, ready attentiveness of a servant watching a master's hand for the smallest signal—waiting that is active, not idle. Naming contempt specifically, including its source in the comfortable and the proud, is treated as legitimate content for prayer rather than something to suppress.

Application for life today.

Consider what it would mean to wait on God the way a servant watches a master's hand—not distracted or resigned, but alert and ready to respond the instant He moves, rather than simply passing time until relief arrives. If you are currently facing contempt or scorn, especially from people who are themselves comfortable or proud, bring that specific dynamic to God in prayer rather than absorbing it silently. Practice the repeated plea of verse 3—'have mercy upon us'—as a model for persistent, undecorated request when eloquence feels impossible.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would it look like to wait on God with the alert, ready attentiveness of a servant watching a master's hand (v. 2), rather than passive or distracted waiting?

2. Who in your life fits the psalm's description of contempt coming from those who are themselves 'at ease' and 'proud' (v. 4), and how does naming that dynamic in prayer change how you carry it?

3. How does the psalm's simple, repeated plea—"have mercy upon us" (v. 3)—give you permission to pray plainly when you cannot find more eloquent words?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).